



BRAIN WASTE



Scan to review worksheet

Expemo code:

1H8M-I1L9-4D5



1

Warm up

In pairs, discuss the following questions.

1. When people come to your country to work, where do they mainly come from?
2. What kind of problems do you think they face?
3. What kind of problems do you think you would experience if you moved to another country to work?

2

Focus on vocabulary

Part A: Match the vocabulary to the definitions.

- | | |
|--------------------------------|---|
| 1. <u>prejudice</u> (n) | a. a person that moves from one country to another in search of work or a better life |
| 2. <u>screen</u> (v) | b. an impossible situation where you can't access one thing without a second thing, but can't get the second thing without the first thing. |
| 3. <u>aptitude</u> (n) | c. achieve something after a lot of effort |
| 4. <u>migrant</u> (n) | d. carefully look for a person or a quality in a person amongst a large group of people |
| 5. <u>attain</u> (v) | e. starting from the very beginning of a process |
| 6. <u>Catch-22</u> (idiom) | f. the ability to be good at something without any real difficulty |
| 7. from <u>scratch</u> (idiom) | g. the negative judgement of someone based on their gender, race, colour etc. |



Part B: Now put the vocabulary from Part A into the correct gaps in the following sentences. You may have to change the form of the word.

1. The company only really hires the best people and they _____ their candidates quite carefully.
2. I never really had any _____ for science when I was at school. I was always much more interested in art and English.
3. I've decided my presentation is terrible, so I'm scrapping it and starting _____.
4. The company has benefitted from the recent influx of well-qualified _____ to the area.
5. Homeless people are often faced with a _____ situation: they can't get a job until they have an address, but they can't get an address without a job.
6. It took several years of hard work, but Martha was able to _____ her MBA while also working full time.
7. I think there's a lot of _____ towards people with an accent like mine. There's just this assumption that I'm not well-educated.

Now in pairs, discuss the following questions.

1. When was the last time you began something **from scratch**? Did you enjoy it? Why/why not?
2. Have you ever been the victim of **prejudice**? What happened?
3. Have you ever found yourself in a **Catch-22** situation? What happened?

3

Scanning for details

Quickly read the article on page four to find what the following numbers mean. Write down the answer.

- a. 15: _____
- b. 100+: _____
- c. 2: _____
- d. 36: _____
- e. 52: _____
- f. 40: _____



A lose-lose situation

The problem of brain waste

- A. When the violence of the war in Yemen forced Mohammed Aldhaferi to leave his homeland, he'd been working as a computer programmer for 15 years and had a degree from a top college. When he arrived in the US state of Michigan, he applied for work in the same field, assuming he'd be able to find a job of a similar level. Two years and over 100 job applications later, he was less confident. To earn money in the meantime, Mohammed was forced to take low-paid jobs, delivering flowers, food and online purchases, while he continued with applications. He was caught in a Catch-22 situation where potential employers were asking for experience working in America which he couldn't get because no one in America would give him a job. It was soul-destroying.
- B. Fortunately, he found an organisation, Michigan International Talent Solutions, which matched professionals arriving from abroad with jobs which needed their skills. The company provided courses to improve his English and refresh his IT knowledge. Another downside of the situation is the longer you are away from a particular profession, the more likely you are to lose out on the latest changes, making it even harder to secure work. The courses put a stop to this. It also helped him with practical aspects of his work search. His CV, for example, was still in the Yemeni tradition of a long, detailed document. It is likely that he wasn't passing the initial screening process because of this, so he changed the format of his CV to make it more appropriate for the American application process. Ultimately, Mohammed found work giving technical support in a hospital allowing him to use his aptitude for computers more effectively.
- C. Mohammed's story is not unique, however. Migrants from other countries often face numerous obstacles in their search for work. There's often an issue with different countries having different licences to do a particular job. If your qualification isn't recognised in the new country, it can be as though you have never trained for that job at all and have to start from scratch. In addition, migrants frequently face language barriers and prejudice in their new homes. Yet, it's a problem that is often not addressed: if skilled workers are arriving from other countries and are not able to use those skills, then no one wins. The country doesn't gain from their expertise and frequently, they are forced to live on a lower income doing a job that they are vastly overqualified for: a phenomenon known as 'brain waste'. Research shows that anywhere from a fifth to a quarter of college-educated arrivals to the United States are underemployed. In Argentina, 36% were unemployed and 52% underemployed. When new arrivals aren't working to their full potential, the country loses the tax they would generate and it's enormous. It is estimated that the United States loses around \$40 billion each year this way.
- D. Some countries are making changes though. The demand for healthcare workers fuelled by the Covid-19 pandemic has led to a change in regulations in some places. The UK introduced the Medical Worker Support Scheme allowing doctors with qualifications from abroad to work in hospitals there without having to attain the official registration. Peru and Colombia also reduced the barriers for qualified migrants to work in their hospitals. In the US, there has been an increase in the number of places new arrivals can take their English proficiency tests for work. However, there is still much to do to ensure that everyone benefits from the skills that qualified migrants bring.

Sources: BBC, LSE, MPI, UNESCO





4

Scanning for vocabulary

Part A: Find words in the article on page four which mean the same as the following.

1. _____ (v) believe something is true without having any evidence (paragraph A)
2. _____ (adj.) boring and repetitive with no obvious end in sight (paragraph A)
3. _____ (n) a negative aspect (paragraph B)
4. _____ (n) the way something is arranged or designed (paragraph B)
5. _____ (n) a qualification which allows you to do a certain job (paragraph C)
6. _____ (n) a physical or imagined obstacle which prevents you from doing something or makes it much harder (paragraph C)
7. _____ (n) someone's qualities which can be developed allowing them to do a particular job (paragraph C)
8. _____ (n) the need for a particular product or service (paragraph D)

Part B: Now use the vocabulary you found to complete the following questions.

1. What are the _____ requirements for CVs in your country?
2. What do you think has been the biggest _____ to you learning English?
3. Do you require a _____ to do your particular job? Why/why not?
4. What is the most _____ job that you've ever done?
5. What did you _____ about learning English which later turned out not to be true?
6. What do you think you have the _____ to do in your career over the next 10 years?
7. What would you say is the biggest _____ to your job?
8. In the last two years, has the _____ for the products or services which your company provides increased or decreased? Why is this?

Now in pairs, answer the questions.





5

Reading comprehension

Read the following statements and decide if they are true (T), false (F) or not given (NG).

1. Mohammed Aldhaferi is a Yemeni native. _____
2. Mohammed took more than one job at the same time to make enough money to live. _____
3. Michigan International Talent Solutions helped Americans find work abroad. _____
4. When he arrived in the US, Mohammed's CV prevented him finding work. _____
5. Professional qualifications in one country are usually compatible with similar qualifications in another country. _____
6. In the US, up to 25% of migrants do not have enough work. _____
7. In the UK, doctors who qualified abroad can work as doctors in hospitals. _____
8. There are more places to take English qualifications for working in the US now than there used to be. _____

6

Listening for details

Listen to the interview and complete the notes about the speaker with one or two words.



Name: Abdul-Aziz

Native Country: 1. _____

Employment history: Over ten years' experience as a 2. _____.

Languages spoken: Farsi, English, Arabic, 3. _____

Family: Uncle lives in 4. _____ London.

Ambition: To work for 5. _____ or 6. _____.

Currently works in a: 7. _____.

Runs his own: 8. _____.



7 Talking point

Listen to the interview again and in pairs, and discuss the following questions.

1. Do you think Abdul-Aziz's hope that he might be able to continue his career in the UK was realistic? Why/why not?
2. Abdul-Aziz mentioned he experienced 'culture shock'. What does this mean? Have you experienced it? What was it like?
3. What would you have done in Abdul-Aziz's situation?
4. Do you think a government has a responsibility to help immigrants find appropriate work when they arrive in the country? Why/why not?
5. Do you have anyone you know who lives in the foreign country? What has their experience of living there been like?
6. What do you think can be done to make it easier for skilled workers to find appropriate work when they arrive in a new country?

8 Extended activity/Homework

In the article on page 4, the adjectives *underemployed* (meaning not having enough work) and *overqualified* (meaning having more qualifications than are needed for the job that they are doing) are used. Complete the table to decide if the prefixes 'over-' and 'under-' can be used with the core word.

core word	under-	over-
1. employed	✓	x
2. qualified	✓	✓
3. rated		
4. worked		
5. confident		
6. cooked		
7. weight		
8. look		
9. achiever		
10. haul		
11. ride		